

Speakers

Expect to see a slew of speakers that take sound to a new high. Multi-channel speakers have already become a norm. 7.1 channel sound cards have been developed to channelise sound in the right manner.

Though not yet a craze, wireless speakers are bound to attract the audiophile because of the flexibility and freedom they offer. Speakers that automatically calibrate and adjust sound quality are also on the cards.

Do Remember

Place the speakers at, or slightly above, ear level for opti-

mum effect. You can place the subwoofer anywhere. Keeps the subwoofer facing a wall, preferably in a corner of the room.

If the surround-sound channels are too faint, 'toe-in' the surround speakers so that they point towards the listener. Conversely, if they are too prominent, place them facing the wall. This helps disperse the sound from the rear channels, resulting in a more enveloping effect.

If you use an adapter that did not come with your speakers, make sure that the ratings of the amplifier (in RMS

Buying Tips

- ✓ **POWER RATING:** Most speaker systems deceptively specify their power rating in Peak Music Power Output (PMPO). Always go by the RMS power: it is the true technical measure of the speaker's capability to handle continuous power. A 40-watt RMS rating for a surround sound speaker system is decent enough.
- ✓ **FREQUENCY RESPONSE:** If your speaker system has a frequency range that's limited at the upper end to, say, 16 KHz, the higher treble notes don't get noticed, especially when playing classical music. Similarly, if your speakers can't go below 50 Hz, they won't be able to render that deep bass from drums, and those thunderous explosions that you come across in movies.
- ✓ **STANDS:** You won't need stands for a 2.1 speaker system that's primarily meant for music playback. You would probably place them right on your desk. However, for a 4.1 or 5.1 speaker system, ensure that all the satellites have a stand or a base attached. This is useful if you want to place them standing on the floor at ear-level, for proper surround sound imaging.

- ✓ **CONTROLS:** Speakers with inline volume controls give you the freedom to control the master speaker volume without going to the trouble of accessing the subwoofer, where the volume controls are generally placed.
- ✓ **AUDIO INPUTS:** If you have a 2.1 stereo speaker system, you only need standard analogue left and right channels. However, in the case of a four-point surround sound system, you would need to look for four separate channels of analogue audio inputs to your speaker system. This would be in the form of two 3.5 mm stereo inputs (left and right for front, and left and right for rear), or four separate RCA inputs. Watch out for pseudo-four channel speakers that are actually just stereo, with two speakers for each side. In the case of 5.1 speakers, you would either need to have six separate RCA inputs for the discrete AC-3 channels, if the signal is already being split by an external decoder, or you would need a DIN connector that is fed by the digital output of your sound card, in order to have true Dolby Digital rendering on your surround sound system.

Ready Reckoner

 You Need	A cost-effective solution
Look for	A 4.1 speaker system that is well-suited for DVD playback
 You Need	Speakers to play games
Look for	A 5.1 speaker system that performs very well, especially when reproducing game sound effects
 You Need	A home theatre system
Look for	A 7.1 speaker system with a large and powerful subwoofer, and punchy satellites

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wattage) and adapter (in Ohms) match.

Before you buy a new speaker set make sure you have the required space to place them properly, else you won't be able to reproduce perfect sound effects.

Before investing in a 4.1 or 5.1 speaker makes sure you have the right hardware to get the maximum out of the sound box.

On-board sound hardware though good enough lacks the fidelity and hence coupling them with good speaker ain't going to do any justice. If you are an audiophile make sure you get a decent hardware to drive your speakers.

While extending speaker wires refer to the manufacturers manual for any source of signal attenuation- signal loss, due to impedance mismatching etc.

Prefer a speaker with wireless remote over wired remotes for the convenience they offer.